

Where does your AI agent live?

ONE DAY, THREE AGENTS

Session browser agent



one task in your browser, then gone

Self-hosted agent



wakes on a timer · your hardware · you maintain it

Managed personal server



wakes on a timer · vendor data center · always on

12am

6am

12pm

6pm

12am

Same agent, three different homes

	SESSION BROWSER	SELF-HOSTED	MANAGED SERVER
EXAMPLE	ChatGPT Atlas; Gemini Agent in Chrome	OpenClaw	Zo Computer
LIVES FOR	One task	As long as your machine is on	Always on
SYSADMIN	The vendor	You	The vendor
YOU PAY	Your AI subscription	Free software + hardware + your own model bill	Plan + metered credits credits ≈ half the price on Basic and Ultra
2026 SIGNAL	Labs consolidating Atlas standalone ended; Mariner folded into Chrome	247K+ GitHub stars 2.0 shipped Aug 30, adding shared cloud sessions	\$7.84M seed Lightspeed, Craft Ventures, Factorial Capital

How a hidden line becomes an action

1 · INBOX

An email carries a line written for the agent

2 · SCHEDULE

3:00am: a scheduled job wakes it to sort mail

3 · KEYS

OAuth tokens: valet keys to mail, calendar, files

4 · ACTION

It can't tell that line from yours, so it acts

no human in the loop

OPENCLAW, JAN–FEB 2026

335

malicious add-on "skills"
in its marketplace

21.6K+

instances exposed
on the public internet

Source: Wikipedia, OpenClaw, 2026. Flow is a schematic of the attack class, not a specific incident.

What makes always-on trustworthy?

Four answers the field is testing, none settled:

WALLS

A sandbox by default: a walled-off space the agent can't reach past

SCOPED KEYS

Each scheduled job gets only the permissions that job needs

A SPENDING CAP

Metered credits limit how much can run unattended

READABLE CODE

Open source you can audit and host yourself